



Sarah's 2027

Science Bee Journey

A novice's guide — what bees are, why they matter, and the 12-month plan from chapters to nationals

Sarah will be in Grade 3 during the entire competition window.

Prepared for Shell · April 2026



What is a Science Bee?

Think of a spelling bee — but for science.

Kids are asked science questions. They have to answer fast — usually inside 30 seconds — without notes, hints, or a calculator. Top scorers advance from a regional round to a national championship.

Two formats: WRITTEN (multiple-choice on paper or screen) and BUZZER (read aloud, kids race to ring in).

1

What they test

Vocabulary, named facts, sequences, common misconceptions, exclusions ("which is NOT").

2

Question speed

~30 seconds per question. No hints. Single best answer.

3

Where they lead

Regional → National Championships. Winners get medals, savings bonds, scholarships.



Why this matters for Sarah

200+

science vocabulary words

Built up over a year, retained via spaced repetition.

36

BFSU chapters at depth

The full curriculum, anchored to a real-world goal.

Many

rapid-recall reps

A skill that pays off in every test, exam, and interview for life.

1

shared family project

Goal-driven homeschooling with measurable wins along the way.

Even if she doesn't win, the prep alone produces real, measurable learning gain.



Sarah's competition landscape

Two PRIMARY targets in the US (her competition window). Two OPTIONAL India events as low-stakes practice.

PRIMARY (US)

— National Science Bee Elementary

Buzzer-style. Online qualifier → regional → Nationals (Orlando, May 2027). Sarah competes in the 3rd Grade division.

— NorthSouth Foundation Junior Science Bee

Written. 30 questions / 30 minutes online. Grades 1-3 (Sarah eligible). Regionals Apr-Jun, Nationals Aug 2027.

OPTIONAL (India practice)

— SOF International Science Olympiad — Class 3

Nov 19 or Dec 3, 2026. Pure MCQ practice. Skip if stressed.

— NSTSE Class 3 (Unified Council)

Jan 2027. Written, no negative marking. Single low-stakes attempt.

Cut from earlier plan: Silverzone iOS (redundant with SOF).



Target #1 — National Science Bee Elementary

Run by IAC (International Academic Competitions) · iaccompetitions.com

Sarah's division at Nationals: 3rd Grade (split off from "3rd & Younger" starting in 2026)

1

Online Qualifier

50 MCQs · 20 minutes
4 attempts allowed Sep 2026 - Mar 2027
~\$25/attempt

2

Regional Tournament

3 buzzer-based prelim rounds + final round
In-person OR online options

3

Nationals

May 21-25, 2027 in Orlando, FL
4 prelim rounds + 2-3 playoff rounds
Medals + savings bonds for top finishers

Up to 4 qualifier attempts is the secret sauce — early ones are diagnostic, later ones competitive.



Target #2 — NorthSouth Foundation Junior Science Bee

The friendlier bee — perfect first competition

Run by volunteer-led NorthSouth Foundation (NSF). Low-pressure, supportive community, free sample papers, and a syllabus designed for Grades 1-3 specifically.

Format: 30 questions in 30 minutes, online. Single phase per regional. Top scorers per regional advance to Nationals.

Schedule for 2026-27

- Regional contests: Apr - Jun 2027
- National finals: Aug 2027
- Registration window: Feb - Apr 2027

AT A GLANCE

FORMAT

Online written

ELIGIBILITY

Grades 1-3

QUESTIONS

30 in 30 min

DIFFICULTY

Beginner-friendly

COST

Low / volunteer-led



How homeschoolers participate

Both bees explicitly accept homeschool students. No association membership required.

NSB ELEMENTARY • IAC

Register Sarah as an individual

1. Create an account at iacompetitions.com
2. Pay the qualifier fee (~\$25) per attempt
3. Take the online qualifier from home
4. If invited to Regional, attend in person
OR online (her choice)
5. If invited to Nationals, travel to Orlando
(May 21-25, 2027)

Individual events need no team or association.

NSF JUNIOR SCIENCE BEE

Register through your nearest chapter

1. Visit northsouth.org/regional-contests
2. Find the chapter nearest your home
3. Register with that chapter (some require
a small membership fee, ~\$25)
4. Take the regional online (30 Q / 30 min)
5. Top scorers per region advance to
Nationals (Aug 2027)

Chapters are volunteer-led and friendly to first-timers.



The 12-month roadmap

Apr 2026 - Aug 2027 · five phases, each with a clear job

Foundation

May - Sep 2026

First Qualifier

Oct - Dec 2026

Build Speed

Jan - Feb 2027

Compete

Mar - Jun 2027

Capstone

May - Aug 2027



Key insight

Chapter completion (~Oct 9, 2026) lines up perfectly with the first NSB qualifier window opening in Sep 2026. The early qualifier attempts are diagnostic; she's not under pressure to win them.



Build the foundation

PRIMARY: BFSU chapter sprint

- 36 chapters, 51 sessions total
- 3 sessions/week starting May 4, 2026
- 6 weeks of slip baked in (travel, illness)
- Projected finish: Friday Oct 9, 2026

ON THE SIDE: 10 min/day bee prep

- DK Encyclopedia (read 2 pages, Mon/Wed/Fri)
- Spectrum Science Grade 3 (1 page Tue/Thu)
- Word jar — 1 new index card per day
- Bee Quiz tab on the chapter just completed

WHAT THE SATURDAY 15 MIN INCLUDES

5 random word jar cards

Shake the jar, pull 5 with eyes closed. Sarah defines each aloud.

1 NSF JSC sample question

Parent reads aloud (buzzer practice). Score: right or wrong, no half-credit.

Quick DK page flip

Sarah picks 1 page from the week she liked best. Re-read together.

Streak tally

Aim for 4+/5 cards correct. Celebrate the streak — sticker on a wall chart.



First NSB qualifier (diagnostic)

Chapters complete by mid-October. Time freed up shifts to bee work:

Spiral review of weak topics

(use word jar misses as the index)

Re-study what gave Sarah trouble last week. The word jar already tracks this — cards she got wrong recently point to topics that need more work. Open the chapter that word came from, redo the lesson section, OR re-read the matching DK pages. Goal: turn a weak topic into a strong one before moving on.

Bee-mode runs on completed chapters

(re-take the Bee Quiz on a chapter from weeks ago)

Open a chapter she completed 2-3 weeks ago. Click the Bee Quiz tab (the bee icon). Take it timed, no hints. Score should be similar or better than the first time. If it dropped a lot, that chapter needs a refresher. This is spaced repetition for chapter understanding — same logic as the word jar but for whole topics.

Plus:

- Drop Spectrum workbook → switch to actual NSB past questions (free IAC archive)
- Continue DK reading + word jar daily

KEY EVENTS

Late Sep / Early Oct

NSB Qualifier #1 — pure baseline, no pressure

Nov 19 OR Dec 3

OPTIONAL: SOF ISO Class 3 — written MCQ practice

Target on attempt #1: 30/50+



Build buzzer speed

Weekly cadence (~30 min/day)

Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
10 NSB-style MCQs (written)	15 buzzer-style oral Qs • 5 sec to answer	10 NSB MCQs • weak- topic focus	15 buzzer drills + DK gap-fill	Bee-mode quiz on a chapter she did months ago	Full mock NSB qualifier — 50 MCQ / 20 min	OFF

Two qualifier attempts + optional NSTSE

- Jan 2027 — NSB Qualifier Attempt #2 (target 35/50+)
- Jan 2027 — OPTIONAL: NSTSE Class 3 (single low-stakes attempt)
- Feb 2027 — NSB Qualifier Attempt #3 (target 40/50+)

Goal: qualify for an NSB Regional Tournament by attempt #3.

PHASES D & E • MAR - AUG 2027

Compete & celebrate

MAR

NSB Qualifier #4

Final attempt if needed.
Full-pressure run.

APR

**NSB Regional
Tournament**

Buzzer rounds in person
or online. 3 prelim + 1 final.

MAY

**NSB Nationals •
Orlando**

May 21-25, 2027.
If she qualified through Regional.

AUG

NSF JSC Nationals

If she placed at the
spring JSC regional.

Even reaching Regionals is a major win for a 3rd grader.



How prep slots into Sarah's week

3 hrs

BFSU chapter sessions

3 sessions/week × 60 min

75 min

DK + workbook + jar

10 min/day × 6 days + Sat

4.25 hrs

TOTAL per week

Reasonable for a 3rd grader

Weekly pattern

Mon · Wed · Fri → Chapter session + DK reading
Tue · Thu → Spectrum workbook page (~5 questions)
Saturday → 15-min word jar review + 1 NSF JSC sample question
Sunday → OFF



Reading strategy: DK + your science reader

Sequential or chapter-matched? Recommendation: a hybrid that flips between the two.

SEQUENTIAL

- ✓ Comprehensive coverage, no gaps.
- ✗ Disconnected from current BFSU chapter; she may read about plants while studying matter.

CHAPTER-MATCHED

- ✓ Reinforces the BFSU topic she's on. Easier mastery.
- ✗ May skip DK topics that BFSU doesn't cover.

Same hybrid applies to any second reader (Spectrum, Science Wonders, etc.)

MY RECOMMENDATION • HYBRID

Match BFSU now, sweep later, drill last.

- PHASE A (May-Sep '26) Read DK sections that match the BFSU chapter she's on. Read AHEAD to prime; re-read AFTER to deepen.
- PHASE B (Oct '26 →) Chapters done. Sweep DK sections BFSU didn't cover.
- PHASE C+ (Jan '27 →) DK becomes targeted gap-fill on weak topics surfaced by quiz misses.



The Word Jar — physical setup

A small physical jar of vocabulary cards Sarah owns. The single highest-leverage tool in this plan.

MATERIALS

- A small jar (mason, decorative box, or candy jar)
- ~100 plain 3×5 index cards
- Markers + stickers + washi tape for decoration
- Sarah's favorite pen

Cost: ~\$5-10 total

CARD FORMAT

FRONT

- Word in big block letters
- Small drawing she does of what it means

BACK

- Definition in her own words
- Example sentence
- Tick marks (one per correct review)

DAILY ROUTINE

Mon / Wed

After DK reading, Sarah picks 1 word she didn't know. Writes it, draws it, defines it. Drops in jar.

Saturday

Pull 5 random cards (eyes closed). She defines aloud. Right = tick. Wrong = goes to front of jar for next week.

After 4 ticks

Card graduates → gold-star sticker → "Mastered" pile. Re-checked monthly.



How the Bee Quiz tab fits her week

Each chapter HTML has a Bee Quiz tab (15 questions, three modes). Use it three different ways.



AFTER each chapter completes

Quick 5 • ~2 min

Sarah takes Quick 5 right after finishing the chapter. Solidifies vocab and tests recall while it's fresh. ~10 min into the day she completes the chapter.



WEEKLY review (Friday)

Full 15 • ~7 min

Open a chapter she finished 2-3 weeks ago. Take Bee Mode in full. Score should hold or improve. If it dropped, that chapter goes back into spiral review.



AFTER 5 chapters done (Saturday)

Mixed Review • ~5 min

Pulls 10 questions across all completed chapters at random. The cross-chapter test that catches misconceptions and forgotten vocab.

All scores auto-sync to Notion → Sarah Bee Quiz Attempts database. Trend over time is the parent dashboard.



The tools we built for Sarah

Three pieces. One unified system. All data syncs to Notion automatically.



BFSU chapter web apps

38 chapter HTML files covering Life, Energy, Matter, Forces, Earth/Space. Each chapter has lessons, homework, and a 30-question mastery quiz.



Bee Quiz tab in each chapter

15 bee-style MCQs per chapter. Three modes: Quick 5, Full 15, Mixed Review. 30-sec timer. Word Cards section below.



Word Jar ([word-jar.html](#))

Daily aggregator across all chapters. Leitner spaced repetition (NEW → LEARNING → MASTERED). 8 cards/day. Streak tracker.



Buy these now (~\$28)

Phase A primary stack — order from Amazon this week.

PRIMARY

\$13

DK First Encyclopedia of Science

Ages 6-9, ~128 pages.
12 themed sections covering most of BFSU.
Visual recall — fact-density per page is high.

PRIMARY

\$12

Spectrum Science Grade 3

Carson Dellosa, 144 pages.
7 chapters: Inquiry, Physical, Life, Earth & Space, Tech, Personal/Social, History.
Reading-passage + comprehension format.

PRIMARY

\$3

Index cards + small jar

~100 plain 3×5 cards.
For the daily word jar.
Let Sarah decorate the jar — ownership matters.

Phase C add-ons (Jan 2027): Spectrum Science Grade 4 + DK Science Encyclopedia (ages 9-12) — ~\$25 more.



Free online resources

Bookmark these. Cost: \$0.



IAC NSB Past Questions Archive

iaccompetitions.com/.../past-questions

Actual NSB-format questions from prior years. Daily MCQ practice from Phase B onwards.



NSF JSC Sample Paper (PDF)

northsouth.org/.../JSC_SampleQ.pdf

Free 30-question sample. Print and try monthly during Phase A.



NASA Space Place

spaceplace.nasa.gov

Astronomy is heavily weighted in NSB. Kid-friendly articles, videos, games.



Mystery Science (free tier)

mysteryscience.com

K-5 video mini-lessons. Aligned with NGSS. Great for visual learners.



SciShow Kids · YouTube

youtube.com/c/scishowkids

Short, energetic explainer videos. Build science vocabulary in context.



Crash Course Kids · YouTube

youtube.com/c/crashcoursekids

4-min episodes covering most elementary bee topics. Watch one per chapter.



Sample papers & must-watch videos

Sample papers (free PDFs)

NSF Junior Science Bee (Grades 1-3)

northsouth.org/wp-content/uploads/2025/01/JSC_SampleQ.pdf

NSF Intermediate (Grades 4-5) — for ref

northsouth.org/wp-content/uploads/2025/01/ISC_SampleQ.pdf

NSF older Junior sample (2013 Nalini)

portal.northsouth.org/.../2013R15JSC_Nalini.pdf

IAC NSB past questions archive

iaccompetitions.com/national-science-bee-...past-questions/

Watch with Sarah (YouTube)

2025 IAC Science Bee Finals — 3rd & Under

youtube.com/watch?v=60XiE-_yXCg

★ Her exact age group. Watch first.

2023 NSB — 4th & Under Finals

youtube.com/watch?v=mXmmynaR9fA

See the buzzer rounds in action.

2023 Elementary & Middle Championships

youtube.com/playlist?list=PLR_HebM9S1ki...

Full playlist — multiple grades.

IAC Science Bee Finals — 6th Grade

youtube.com/watch?v=tVmeLVpRPow

Goal-state preview.

Tip: watch the 2025 3rd & Under Finals together — it makes the goal feel real, not abstract.



What success looks like

REALISTIC

Qualify for NSF JSC regional

Single attempt, low-pressure. Most prepared 3rd graders make it.

STRETCH

Qualify for NSB Regional Tournament

Across 4 qualifier attempts. Score in top ~30% of Sarah's age band.

BIG STRETCH

Compete at NSB Nationals • Orlando

Qualify through the regional. Top performers get savings bonds + medals.

THE REAL WIN: 200+ vocabulary words, 36 chapters of deep science, lifelong recall habits.

THIS WEEK

Five things to start the journey

1

Order books on Amazon (~\$28)

DK First Encyclopedia of Science · Spectrum Science Grade 3 · Index cards + jar

2

Set up the word jar with Sarah

Decorate it together. Goal: 50 cards by September.

3

Watch the 2025 NSB Finals together

2025 IAC Science Bee 3rd & Under (YouTube). Makes the goal feel real.

4

Start chapter session #1

Monday May 4, 2026. Begin BFSU at 3 sessions/week.

5

Test the Bee Quiz prototype

Open chapter-d3a-directions.html → Bee Quiz tab → Quick 5. Confirm Notion sync.

First step is always the hardest. Books on order = momentum.